IN **BAINGWADI, A SMALL VILLAGE** tucked deep inside Uttarakhand's Pauri district, the silence begins long before the houses appear. "There are only empty houses and hanging locks to welcome you here," says Pratap Singh, 85, a retired sub-inspector of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police, who lives alone. Of his two brothers, one has settled in Pauri town, the other in Dehradun. His three daughters and one son all live outside the state. "There is no one left," he says quietly. "People come back only when there is a wedding or a ritual that must be held here." Village pradhan Manvendra Rawat says of the village's 392 registered voters, 125 live elsewhere. "Even the MGNREGA public works are incomplete. There is no one left to do it," says Rawat.

The local school still stands, but with barely any children. Teachers, desperate to keep the school open and avoid a transfer, often pay out of their own pockets for the travel, food and uniforms of the wards. Yet, more schools stand sans students every year in the remote reaches. Many families have stopped sending their children after leopard sightings became frequent.

If Pauri's hills tell a story of absence, neighbouring Tehri Garhwal district offers a glimpse of what that looks like at scale. In several villages of Ghansali tehsil, outmigration is so widespread that locals now call the area "Mini Japan", a nickname



SITA DEVI, 55, (left) and MEERA DEVI, 65
Sarpoli village, *Tehri Garhwal*

"HE SAYS HE'LL COME SOON..."

In Sarpoli village, Sita Devi's day begins before sunrise and winds down with the sunset. She is 55 and lives in a two-room house on the slopes. Her *jethani* (sister-in-law), Meera Devi, lives next door. Meera's daughter and son-in-law work in Nainital, and their trips home have grown fewer over the years.

Sita's own family is mostly elsewhere. Her husband has been in Russia for the past two years, working as a cook in a hotel. Their elder son is in the same line and works in Dubai. The younger son works in Mumbai. The house feels alive only during the festivals when her sons and their families come. But those days pass quickly.

Most days are predictable here. Sita fills her hours with daily chores—fetching water, cooking, keeping watch for wild animals on her patch of land. Her husband calls late at night when he can. "He keeps saying he will leave the job and come back. He is unhappy and tired, but is bound by the contract. Even when he returns, he will have to look for work again soon," she says.

Between the two women, the houses stay open, and the conversation moves between shared worries and small comforts. In a village where nearly every family is split across cities and countries, Sita and Meera hold on to what is left of the lives they have built together.